

The Tripartite Tractate

Codex Reference: I,5

Translated by: Harold W. Attridge, Elaine H. Pagels, and Dieter Mueller

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Harold W. Attridge and Elaine H. Pagels

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The final tractate of Codex I is an elaborate, but untitled, Valentinian theological treatise which gives an account of the whole process of devolution from and reintegration into the primordial godhead. The text is divided by scribal decoration into three segments which contain the major acts of the cosmic drama; hence its modern title.

The date of composition can only be determined within broad limits. Since the doctrine of the text represents a revised form of Valentinian theology which may be a response to the criticism of orthodox theologians such as Irenaeus or Hippolytus, the work was probably written in the early to mid third century. The text displays some affinities with Origen's doctrines, although these may be due to common theological and philosophical sources.

The tractate offers no information about the identity of its author. Some scholars have speculated that the Valentinian teacher Heracleon could have written the work. While there are affinities with Heracleon and the Western or Italian school of Valentinianism, the work departs from classical Valentinian doctrine more radically than any known representative of the tradition.

Like the other tractates of Codex I and most of the works in the Nag Hammadi collection, *The Tripartite Tractate* was originally composed in Greek. The Coptic translation presents numerous difficulties and obscurities, many of which probably reflect the style of the original.

The theological purview of the tractate is comprehensive. The first part (51,1–104,3) describes the emanation of all supernatural entities from their primal source. It begins with the Father (51,1–57,8), described primarily through a *via negativa* as an utterly transcendent entity. What can be affirmed is that he is unique and monadic. The insistence on the unitary character of the Father distinguishes the text from most other Valentinians who posit a primal masculine-feminine dyad, although some members of the school, such as those mentioned by Hippolytus (Ref. 6.29.2–8), also hold to a monadic first principle.

Emanating from the Father are two other entities, the Son and the Church (57,8–59,38). At this point the tractate again differs from other Valentinian sources, which regularly posit a more complex godhead. The *pleroma* or “fullness of deity” usually consists of an *ogdoad*, a set eight *syzygies*, or pairs of divine entities, a similarly composed *decad*, and *duodecad*. Instead, *The Tripartite Tractate* posits an initial trinity.

Some elements of the complex traditional Valentinian picture are retained in the description of the components or “*aeons*” of the third element of the trinity, the Church (50,1–74,18). The dependence on, as well as revision of, Valentinian sources is clear in the stage of the text which describes the problems created by one of the *aeons* (74,18–80,11). In other Valentinian accounts,

which are based on earlier, non-Christian speculation, the problem in the godhead arises because of a female aeon, Sophia (Wisdom), who attempts to do the impossible. According to different versions of the story, she either tries to produce offspring without her consort or tries to know the unknowable primal source. In either case, she falls outside the divine pleroma and produces the world of psychic and material forces. In *The Tripartite Tractate* the agent of the rupture in the pleroma is a masculine aeon, the Logos (Word). His fall, which includes elements of both traditional explanations of Sophia's catastrophe, is presented in remarkably positive terms, as a result of his own "abundant love" (76,19–20). It is also, remarkably enough, in accordance with the Father's will (76,24–77,1). Most importantly, it proceeds from the Logos' free choice (75,35–76,1), a quality which all entities dependent on him share.

The fall of the Logos produces two orders of beings which are outside the pleroma (80,11–85,15). From his confused and defective procreative activity emerge hylic forces. When the Logos, on his own initiative, repents, he produces psychic forces. These supernatural forces will play a role in creation of the first human and in cosmic governance.

The most important result of the conversion of the Logos is the generation of the Savior (85,15–90,13). This transpires when the Logos splits in two. His better, masculine self returns to the pleroma to intercede for his defective, feminine self. That better self, along with the aeons who have never left the pleroma, produce the Savior. That being is also called, by analogy with the highest level of reality, the Son, because as the Son reveals the Father to the aeons of the pleroma, the Savior will provide revelatory insight to those outside the pleroma.

The brief second part of the tractate (104,4–108,12) offers an interpretation of Genesis 1–3. The first human being is produced on the one hand by the Demiurge and on the other hand by the Logos. The former provides Adam's psychic and material components and the latter his spiritual component. The three potencies of the first human being will later be actualized in three classes of human beings at the coming of the Savior.

The third part of the tractate (108,13–138,27) focuses on soteriological issues. The Savior's appearance divides humankind into three classes (118,14–122,12). The pneumatic or spiritual recognize the Savior immediately and respond to him, while the hylic or material reject him utterly. Between these two extremes the psychic or soulful types hesitate, and only gradually come to join the Savior. As is usual in Valentinian texts, the three types have clear social referents. The pneumatics are the Valentinians themselves, the hylics are non-Christians and the psychics are ordinary Christians. The attention lavished on the detailed description of the psychics is indicative of the apologetic and irenic tendencies of the work.

In its final section (129,34–138,27) the text returns to the issue of the psychic and the process of their salvation. It then proceeds to sketch an eschatological tableau, the last portions of which are quite fragmentary. It concludes with a hymn to "the Savior, the Redeemer of all those who belong to the one filled with love, through his Holy Spirit, from now on through all generations forever" (138,20–25).

The Tripartite Tractate has revised traditional Valentinianism on several key points: in its insistence on the unity of the first principle; in the substitution of a trinity for a more complex godhead; in its portrait of the Logos as the element of the godhead responsible for the rupture in the divine; in its moderate assessment of the psychic demiurge; in its detailed analysis of the triparti-

tion of humanity as a result of the freely chosen response of each individual to the appearance of the Savior; and in the hope of final redemption held out to ordinary Christians. This bold revision of Valentinian speculation serves as the basis for a comprehensive theological statement designed to appeal not simply to an isolated sect, but to the church as a whole.